It's a Good Life

By Jerome Bixby

Aunt Amy was out on the front porch, rocking back and forth in the high-backed chair and fanning herself, when Bill Soames stopped in front of the house. Bill lifted the box of groceries out and came up the front walk.

Little Anthony was sitting on the lawn, playing with a rat. He had caught the rat down in the basement--he had made it think that it smelled cheese, the most rich-smelling and crumbly-delicious cheese a rat had ever thought it smelled, and it had come out of its hole, and now Anthony had hold of it with his mind and was making it do tricks.

When the rat saw Bill Soames coming, it tried to run, but Anthony thought at it, and it turned a flip-flop on the grass, and lay trembling, its eyes gleaming in small black terror.

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Bill Soames hurried past Anthony and reached the front steps, mumbling. He always mumbled when he came to the Fremont house. Everybody did. They tried to jumble up their thoughts to keep them skipping back and forth, so Anthony couldn't read their minds. The mumbling helped. Because if Anthony got anything strong out of your thoughts, he might take a notion to do something about it--like curing your wife's sick headaches or your kid's mumps. That was if he liked you. He might try to help you, in his way. And that could be pretty horrible.

If he didn't like you ... well, that could be worse.

INTRODUCTION

Anthony Fremont is six years old, with a cute little-boy face and blue, guileless eyes. But when those eyes look at you, you'd better start thinking happy thoughts, because the mind behind them is absolutely in charge. It's a Good Life by Jerome Bixby

Bill Soames set the box of groceries on the porch railing and stopped his mumbling long enough to say, "Everythin' you wanted, Miss Amy."

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"Oh, fine, William," Amy Fremont said lightly. "My, ain't it terrible hot today?"

Bill Soames almost cringed. His eyes pleaded with her. He shook his head violently *no*, and then interrupted his mumbling again, though obviously he didn't want to: "Oh, don't say that, Miss Amy ... it's fine, just fine. A real *good* day!"

"Land alive, William," Aunt Amy said, "you don't have to mumble like that. Anthony wouldn't hurt you. My goodness, Anthony likes you!" She raised her voice and called to Anthony, who had tired of the rat and was making it eat itself. "Don't you, dear? Don't you like Mr. Soames?"

Anthony looked across the lawn at the grocery man--a bright, wet, purple gaze. He didn't say anything. After a second Anthony returned his attention to the rat. It had already devoured its tail, or at least chewed it off--for Anthony had made it bite faster than it could swallow.

Mumbling silently, thinking of nothing in particular as hard as he could, Bill Soames went stiff-

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legged down the walk, mounted his bicycle and pedaled off.

"We'll see you tonight, William," Aunt Amy called after him.

Anthony looked at the rat. It had devoured half its belly, and had died from pain. He thought it into a grave out deep in the cornfield--his father had once said, smiling, that he might do that with the things he killed--

Amy went out in back, where Anthony's Mom--Aunt Amy's sister--sat in the shade of the house, shelling peas.

"William brought the groceries," Aunt Amy said.

"Oh, good," said Mom.

Everybody in Peaksville always said "Oh, fine," or "Good," or "Say, that's swell," when almost everything happened or was mentioned--even unhappy things like accidents or even deaths. They'd always say "Good," because if they didn't try to cover up how they really felt, Anthony might overhear with his mind, and then nobody knew what might happen.

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"Tonight's television night," said Aunt Amy. "I'm glad I look forward to it so much every week. I wonder what we'll see tonight?"

"Dan Hollis will be so surprised when he finds out that tonight's television party is a birthday party for him too!"

Anthony liked television night. Everybody came to television and he liked all the attention he got when they did.

Anthony's father came home around six-thirty. "No one told Dan Hollis about its being a birthday party, did they?" his wife asked.

"It's *good*," said Dad, in the loud, familiar, wanting-to-be-overheard tone of voice. Everything's good. Everything *has* to be good . . Had to be fine just as it was, even if it wasn't. Always. Because any changes might be worse. So terribly much worse.

They started arriving around eight o clock.. The candles were burning, and the chairs situated, and Dad had a big fire going in the fireplace.

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The first to arrive were the Sipichs, John and Mary. John wore his best suit, and was well-scrubbed and pink-faced after his day in McIntyre's pasture. The suit was neatly pressed, but getting threadbare at elbows and cuffs. Old McIntyre was working on a loom, designing it out of schoolbooks, but so far it was slow going.

McIntyre had been one of the ones who, at first, had wanted to try to get Anthony to make things the villagers needed, like clothes and canned goods and medical supplies and gasoline. Since then, he felt that what had happened to the whole Terrance family and Joe Kinney was his fault, and he worked hard trying to make it up to the rest of them. And since then, no one had tried to get Anthony to do anything.

The next arrivals were the Smiths and the Dunns, who lived right next to each other down the road, only a few yards from the nothingness. They drove up in the Smiths wagon, drawn by their old horse.

Then the Reillys showed up, from across the darkened wheat field, and the evening really began. Pat

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Reilly sat down at the big upright in the front room, and began to play from the popular sheet music on the rack. He played softly, as expressively as he could--and nobody sang. Anthony liked piano playing a whole lot, but not singing; the one time somebody had started to sing, Anthony had looked over from the top of the piano and done something that made everybody afraid of singing from then on.

So, every television night, Pat would play the piano, and that was the beginning of the evening. Wherever Anthony was, the music would make him happy, and put him in a good mood, and he would know that they were gathering for television and waiting for him.

Dan and Ethel Hollis came late, and Dan walked in not suspecting a thing. "Well, I'll be darned," Dan grinned. "This is swell. I wasn't expecting this at all ... gosh, this is *swell!*"

They gave him his presents--mostly things they had made by hand, though some were things that people had possessed as their own and now gave him as his. \

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Last of all, Thelma Dunn gave Dan Hollis a record she had found. Dan's eyes misted even before he opened the package. He knew it was a record.

"Oh, gosh," Dan said again. Carefully he removed the wrapping and stood there fondling the record, running his big hands over the worn grooves with their tiny, dulling crosswise scratches. He looked around the room, eyes shining, and they all smiled back, knowing how delighted he was.

"Happy birthday, darling!" Ethel said, throwing her arms around him and kissing him.

"Look ... do you think we could play it? Lord, what I'd give to hear some new music ... just the first part, the orchestra part, before Como sings?"

Faces sobered. After a minute, John Sipich said, "I don't think we'd better, Dan. After all, we don't know just where the singer comes in it'd be taking too much of a chance. Better wait till you get home."

It was a pleasant enough get-together, aside from your having to watch what you said just as carefully as you always did everyplace. If a dangerous

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thought came into your mind, you just started mumbling, even right in the middle of a sentence. When you did that, the others just ignored you until you felt happier again and stopped.

Anthony liked television night. He had done only two or three awful things on television night in the whole past year.

Mom had put a bottle of brandy on the table, and they each had a tiny glass of it. Afterward, everybody wished that the brandy hadn't been brought out because Dan Hollis drank more of it than he should have, and mixed it with a lot of the homemade wine. Dan Hollis got high, and did a fool thing., Dan stopped laughing right in the middle of the story. His face got slack, and then it got ugly, and he said, "Oh, *Christ!*"

Immediately the room was still. Pat Reilly had been playing the piano, softly. He stopped, his hands poised over the yellowed keys. "Keep playing, Pat," Anthony's father said softly.

Dan stood in the middle of the room, holding the record. In his other hand he held a glass of brandy so

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hard his hand shook. "*Christ*," he said again, and he made it sound like a dirty word.

John Sipich moved forward. "Now, Dan ... it's *good* for you to talk that way. But you don't want to talk too much, you know."

"Can't even play my record," he said loudly. He threw the glassful of brandy against the wall. It splattered and ran down the wallpaper in streaks.

Pat Reilly was playing louder, to cover up the sounds of the talk. It wouldn't do any good, though, if Anthony was listening.

Dan Hollis went over to the piano and stood by Pat's shoulder, swaying a little. "Pat," he said. "Don't play *that*. Play *this*." And he began to sing. Softly, hoarsely, miserably: "Happy birthday to me... Happy birthday to me..."

"*Dan!*" Ethel Hollis screamed. She tried to run across the room to him. "Dan, stop-"

"--Happy birthday, dear Danny." Dan sang. "Happy birthday to me!" Dan Hollis stared over at the dining-room door. At Anthony's mother, "*You* had him," he said.

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Tears gleamed on his cheeks as the candlelight caught them. "You had to go and have him ..."

Anthony *came* into the room. Pat stopped playing. He froze. Everybody froze. Dan's voice faltered into silence. His eyes widened.

"Bad man," Anthony said, and thought Dan Hollis into something like nothing anyone would have believed possible, and then he thought the thing into a grave deep, deep in the cornfield.

Anthony's purple gaze went around the room. Some of the people began mumbling. They all tried to smile.

"A good thing," said Anthony's father, smiling. He'd had more practice in smiling than most of them. "A wonderful thing."

"It's swell.., just swell," said Pat Reilly, tears leaking from eyes and nose, and he began to play the piano again, softly. Anthony climbed up on top of the piano, and Pat played for two hours.

Afterward, they watched television. They didn't even turn the set on. It wouldn't have worked anyway,

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there being no electricity in Peaksville. They just sat silently, and watched the twisting, writhing shapes on the screen, and listened to the sounds that came out of the speaker, and none of them had any idea of what it was all about. They never did. It was always the same.

"It's real nice," Aunt Amy said once, "But I liked it a little better when there were cities outside and we could get real-"

"Why, Amy!" said Mom. "It's good for you to say such a thing. Very good. But how can you mean it? Why, this television is *much* better than anything we ever used to get!"

"Yes," chimed in John Sipich. "It's fine. It's the best show we've ever seen!"

He sat on the couch, with two other men, holding Ethel Hollis flat against the cushions, holding her arms and legs and putting their hands over her mouth, so she couldn't start screaming again . . .

It did no good to wonder where they were ... no good at all. Peaksville was just someplace. Someplace away from the world. It was wherever it had been since

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that day three years ago when Anthony had crept from her womb and old Doc Bates--God rest him--had screamed and dropped him and tried to kill him, and Anthony had whined and done the thing. He had taken the village someplace. Or had destroyed the world and left only the village, nobody knew which. It did no good to wonder about it. Nothing at all did any good except to live as they must live. Must always, always live, if Anthony would let them. It was a good day.

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